

Chapter 67-3

Outside, it was raining. The fine raindrops condensed on the glass, transforming into slender streams of water that slid down to the windowsill, then along the gray walls and into the earth.

Xu Qingzhu turned on the TV and asked Liang Shi what she wanted to watch.

Liang Shi said whatever.

Then Xu Qingzhu opened a movie—*City of Fantasy*.

Starring: Yang Shuyan.

Liang Shi: "?"

Just one minute into the opening credits, Xu Qingzhu suddenly said: "Oh right, I received a package today."

"What?" Liang Shi still had a pearl in her mouth that she hadn't swallowed, and asked indistinctly: "A gift?"

"Sort of."

Xu Qingzhu bent down slightly, pulled open the coffee table drawer in the living room, and then took out a photo album the size of A4 paper.

Exquisitely bound, it came in a box.

She paused the TV, then focused intently on unpacking the box. After opening it, the cover that was revealed showed a still from Yang Shuyan's film.

The very cool and beautiful red outfit look from that period costume movie.

Liang Shi: "?"

"When I was on that video call last time, I mentioned to Yang Shuyan that I really liked this film of hers, and then she sent me a set of exquisite merchandise, with every page autographed." Xu Qingzhu flipped through it: "She's really very thoughtful."

"Yes." Liang Shi bit down on her straw, "You're the investor daddy¹, so of course she's thoughtful with you."

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu turned her face to the side, "Why so sour?"

Liang Shi immediately widened her eyes and shook her head: "I'm not. But do you know that Sister Ying and Yang Shuyan....."

She paused, the emotions conveyed in her eyes very rich.

"Are a couple?" Xu Qingzhu asked: "But their fans are fighting quite ridiculously. They're practically arguing every day."

"You even watch their fans argue?" Liang Shi was astonished.

"Hm?" Xu Qingzhu said: "I even joined a Weibo² fan group."

Liang Shi: "....."

"The fans don't know about the celebrities' relationships. They're all just guessing blindly." Liang Shi tried hard to steer the direction elsewhere, "Last time when I went to audition for *Afterglow*, Yang Shuyan was there too."

"Mm, I heard she'll have a special appearance in it." Xu Qingzhu looked like she knew everything, then looked at Liang Shi: "Teacher Liang, I'd like to interview you—having just entered the industry and already performing alongside two of the industry's top powerhouse Best Actresses³, what does it feel like?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She was silent for a moment, then said with feigned profundity, "We haven't started filming yet. I'll tell you after we finish shooting."

Xu Qingzhu carefully put away that set of merchandise while saying with a smile: "Alright, then I'll be waiting for Teacher Liang's three-thousand-word reflective essay."

Liang Shi: "?"

What kind of important figure was she?

Why did she have to write three thousand words?!

Liang Shi glanced at her, "Is it because I'm working with your goddess that you want me to write a three-thousand-word reflection?"

"Ah?" Xu Qingzhu was taken aback, then smiled after a moment: "My goddess? Who?"

Liang Shi glanced at the box she had put in the drawer, "There, Yang Shuyan."

"I suppose you could say that." Xu Qingzhu turned on the TV, the corners of her mouth always holding a smile, "Teacher Liang, work hard. Maybe in the future you'll be promoted to become my new goddess."

Liang Shi: "?"

Why did this matter require effort?

Yang Shuyan's line delivery was excellent, her enunciation clear, and full of emotion. Just two lines could immerse people in the scene.

After being modest for over twenty years, Liang Shi suddenly said, "My acting isn't any worse than hers."

Xu Qingzhu didn't even look at her, her tone perfunctory: "Is that so? Then Teacher Liang is really amazing. I look forward to the day you become hugely popular."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Besides, people you see every day can't become goddesses." Liang Shi added another point.

"Ah? Why not?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "Goddesses need to exist ethereally and intangibly, and also, distance creates beauty."

Xu Qingzhu almost choked on a mouthful of bubble tea, then looked at Liang Shi and asked with particular seriousness and surprise: "So, is Teacher Liang jealous?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She immediately denied it: "How could that be?"

Xu Qingzhu chuckled lightly, "It's okay, I understand."

Liang Shi was bewildered: "Understand what?"

"Don't worry, Teacher Liang." Xu Qingzhu patted her shoulder, "Even if I like Yang Shuyan's acting, I won't stop supporting you. I can..... stan both⁴."

Liang Shi: "....."

A few seconds later, Liang Shi removed her hand, grinding her teeth as she said: "You might as well jump ship⁵."

Xu Qingzhu held back and held back, but couldn't hold back her laughter.

But after laughing, she comforted Liang Shi, "Teacher Liang, in the future you'll have lots of fans just like Yang Shuyan."

Liang Shi: ".....Oh."

After several rounds of speechlessness, Liang Shi watched the movie seriously.

Yang Shuyan indeed had a face made for movies, with an innate sense of sophistication.

Her acting was also outstanding. Several veteran actors almost couldn't keep up with her performance.

So young, yet so capable—she must be a naturally talented actress.

Just like Sister Ying.

Footnotes:

¹ Investor daddy: In Chinese entertainment industry slang, "投资人'爸爸'" (tóuzīrén 'bàba') refers to wealthy investors or financial backers of projects. They're called "daddy" because they provide the money that makes projects possible. The term has slightly sarcastic undertones and sometimes implies that favors or special treatment may be exchanged for investment.

² Weibo: China's equivalent of Twitter/X, a major social media platform where celebrities interact with fans and where fan culture thrives. The full name is "Sina Weibo" (新浪微博).

³ Best Actresses: The Chinese term "影后" (yǐnghòu) literally means "Film Queen" or "Movie Queen," a title given to actresses who have won Best Actress awards at major film festivals or ceremonies. In this context, it refers to acclaimed, award-winning actresses with proven acting prowess.

⁴ Stan both: The original Chinese uses "双担" (shuāng dān), which means to be a fan of two celebrities simultaneously. "担" (dān) is fan slang for being a dedicated fan or supporter of a celebrity, derived from "担当" (dāndāng, to take responsibility). "双担" literally means being a fan who supports both.

⁵ Jump ship: The Chinese uses "爬墙" (pá qiáng), which literally means "climb the wall." In fan culture, it refers to a fan abandoning their current favorite celebrity to become a fan of someone else—essentially "jumping ship" or switching allegiances to a different idol.